

Diffusion S-Curve

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Innovators to laggards over time

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

The Diffusion S-Curve charts how an innovation is adopted over time, from a slow start among innovators, through rapid mainstream uptake, to saturation among laggards, tracing an S-shaped cumulative curve.

WHO DEVELOPED IT

Formalised by Everett Rogers in *Diffusion of Innovations* (1962), building on earlier rural-sociology adoption studies.

WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

It was developed to explain the social process of adoption and to identify the distinct adopter categories a new technology must win in sequence.

FIGURE 1 · DIFFUSION S-CURVE

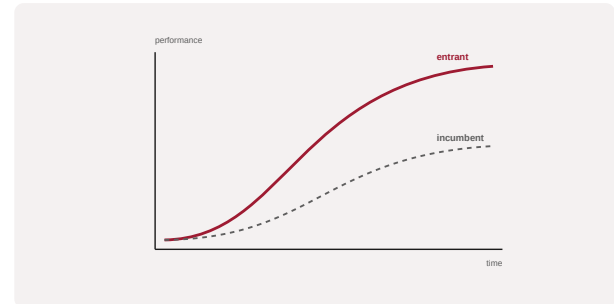


Figure 1. A schematic of the Diffusion S-Curve as applied in BARBM312 (illustrative).

HOW IT IS USED

An innovation's current adoption is located on the curve; strategy is tailored to the next adopter group rather than treating the market as homogeneous.

WHEN IT IS USED

When forecasting AI adoption, timing market entry and segmenting go-to-market.

BY WHOM IT IS USED

Product marketers, strategists and forecasters.

INNOVATION RELATIVE TO THE PREDECESSOR TOOL

It frames adoption as a staged social process rather than a switch, underpinning later models such as Crossing the Chasm.

RELATED FRAMEWORKS IN THIS COURSE

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Adoption → Impact Lag · Slibrary 5

Intangible Capital Iceberg · Slibrary 5

SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Rogers, E.M. (1962) *Diffusion of Innovations*. New York: Free Press.

Bass, F.M. (1969) 'A new product growth model for consumer durables', *Management Science*, 15(5).